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CART 353

September 30th, 2026

Project Proposal: *Concrete Site*

The project is titled *Concrete Site*. The viewer is prompted to use their personal device to access the project; in doing so, they unconsciously provide information to be extracted. The project displays an image of a concrete wall, procedurally generated, which is altered by the viewer's presence on the virtual site. The concrete wall reacts to various components of the viewer's data, changing its visual qualities accordingly. As viewers join the site, the concrete wall changes over time and informs its viewers of these changes through a timeline. As each aspect of the visitor's data is mapped onto a specific visual quality of the image, *Concrete Site* translates how this data correlates to the viewer's material conditions in the outside world. *Concrete Site* critiques the materiality of concrete in relation to its socio-cultural and historical context, while also offering a critique of class and e-tourism in the age of surveillance capitalism. As a final addition to the experience, if the viewer wishes to own a specific iteration of the concrete wall, they are offered the option to print out the image, labelled with the time and date it was affected by a visitor as well as the parameters that led to the iteration (mimicking a Pantone swatch).

I plan to use the techniques of procedural texture generation, procedural rhetoric and emergent narrative. The visual component of the piece will be using a procedural texture generation algorithm that will be running in real-time over a long period of time and reacting to users' data as well as API data. The ideological component of the piece will be using procedural rhetoric to communicate pessimistic notions of concrete as a material, specifically criticizing its relationship to power, wealth and control, and an emergent narrative will take place as the user explores the various iterations of the wall over time (affected by rules pre-defined by the author) to understand the different visual outcomes (produced by the specific interactions between incoming data with its mapped parameters and the procedural algorithm). The project will heavily rely on data extraction and mappings between a user's device (model, browser, location), APIs (such as weather at that location), and the project, acting as both a client and a server for data exchanged over a network (which I will learn to implement more thoroughly in CART 351: Networks and Navigation, class I am taking concurrently).

My project was first strongly influenced by Adam Basanta's *All We'd Ever Need Is One Another*¹. I wanted to create a print as well, with a black box algorithm determining its visual quality and outputting various iterations. Basanta's piece makes use of computer vision and

¹ Basanta, Adam. *All We'd Ever Need is One Another*. 2018. Mixed media installation.
<https://adambasanta.com/allwedeeverneed.php>

machine learning to critique the valuation of art in today's art world and in a meta way creates a valuable product at the same time. The quality of the print, the contextualization of it, the parts of the process made visible, and the parts hidden, make for an especially compelling final product while self-critiquing the very process it was made in. This artificial removal of ownership of the means of productions (his art generator has no master, only an arbitrary model that allows for the commodification of certain iterations) is particularly interesting to me in the context of Marxist Theory as interpreted through Critical Theory. Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer's critique the production of art in the age of modernity in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*: "Art for the masses has destroyed the dream but still conforms to the tenets of that dreaming idealism... Everything derives from consciousness: ... in mass art, from the consciousness of the production team."² In this context, my piece critiques what is considered art, using the banality of a concrete wall to communicate anti-capitalist ideals, reframing materiality as being politically charged.

The main algorithmic approach requires me to use procedural texture generation algorithms. I have never written a procedural texture generation algorithm, although I have written iterative algorithms before. I understand arrays and how to store data in JavaScript. I will need to better understand how to extract data and manipulate it (from users and APIs). I am not sure how computationally expensive it will be to keep the algorithm running over a long period of time.

I want the site to feel very minimalist. I want it to appear banal, uninteresting, maybe a bit intriguing. The concrete wall image should be highly realistic and resemble at once many types of concrete found in the outside world. The image should appear on a white background. The hyperrealism of the concrete wall should feel synthetic and provoke a sense of the uncanny. A timeline should be made available for users to hover over as well as navigate to visualize the evolution of the texture over time. The layering of information over the image when it is printed should feel refined but busy, odd and absurd, evoking the codes of commodification.

² Adorno and Horkheimer, *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, trans. John Cumming (Verso, 1997; original text 1944), 125.

Bibliography

Adorno, Theodor and Horkheimer, Max. "The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception." in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. Translated by John Cumming. Verso, 1997.

Basanta, Adam. *All We'd Ever Need is One Another*. 2018. Mixed media installation.

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